not entirely new; it's just that the past record on implementation has been very poor. For instance, the party will create a public insight department to receive "continuous, scientific feedback" from the people of India. Feedback mechanisms already exist in the party, but in the past, the leadership has often acted against feedback given to it by, say, its data analytics department or by independent agencies. For instance, a report about high anti-incumbency against former Punjab chief minister Captain Amarinder Singh was given to the party high command almost a year before the state went to polls. Yet the party took nearly six months to sack the former CM or take corrective measures. In 2021, the party was advised not to form an alliance with the AIUDF (All India United Democratic Front) in Assam while another internal report talked positively about a tie-up with the Trinamool Congress in West Bengal. On both occasions, the party went and did exactly the opposite of what was suggested.

**MANY FEEL THE PROPOSED NEW COMMITTEES ARE ONLY MEANT TO MOLLIFY THE G23 REBELS**



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It has also decided to form a national training institute for party workers and leaders and an election management department. Well, the party already has an election coordination committee with Rahul Gandhi, C.P. Joshi, Digvijaya Singh, Janardan Dwivedi, Ghulam Nabi Azad, Jairam Ramesh and Randeep Singh Surjewala as members. There is also a training department headed by Rahul's close aide Sachin Rao. It's a different matter that nobody knows when meetings of various Congress departments are held—if at all. There is also no mechanism to monitor and evaluate the performances of these committees.

And yet, the spectacle of committees begetting committees continues. Sonia Gandhi said she would form an advisory group drawn from the CWC to meet regularly and deliberate on political issues and challenges before the party. This decision is baffling, to say the least. By September, the party will elect a new president. According to the party constitution, a new CWC has to be formed after the new president comes in and 12 of its 25 members are to be elected. The rest are nominated by the president. Irrespective of who becomes the new president, a new CWC will have to be constituted. In that case, this advisory group, carved out of the present CWC, will be a very short-lived one.

What's even more ironical is that the Congress president had formed, in September 2020, a six-member committee—which had A.K. Antony, the late Ahmed Patel, Wasnik, Ambika Soni, K.C. Venugopal and Surjewala—to assist her in organisational and operational matters. This was done even though the Congress already has a core committee, which again has Antony, Venugopal and Surjewala, besides Ghulam Nabi Azad, P. Chidambaram, Ashok Gehlot and Jairam Ramesh. Many underwhelmed Congress insiders are asking what radical novelty the new committee will offer.

In fact, the challenge before the task force is precisely to ensure that it bucks the party's own history of sloth. Many suspect the new committee and task force have been announced as a mollificatory gesture—only to accommodate some key members of the rebel G23 group. Several veterans are also likely to turn hostile as they would have lost their Rajya Sabha seats by June and July. So, keeping them in good humour is essential. There is also speculation that this committee will be nothing but the "*margdarshak mandal* of the Congress"—a retirement home for the veterans.

But there is consensus that the Congress itself must find its '*marg*'—or path—now. That's why the leadership question is key as all reforms will have to be driven by a decisive leadership. So must the political battle against the BJP. The collective leadership of the Sonia-Rahul-Priyanka troika has failed to deliver till now. Most Congress insiders say the three must bring urgency and boldness to their decision-making process and, more importantly, end the ad-hocism on presidentship.

At the *shivir*, besides Sonia, Rahul was the only leader who addressed the delegates. By the rule book, he doesn't hold any position, except as a CWC member. Though Rahul has not expressed any overt willingness to take to the helm again, the *shivir* offered some indication that he could contest the presidential poll in September—that will make it an 'uncontested' election, the way it happened in 2017. The whole process may not look very much like 'reform', but at least it will be a decisive change from the rudderless drift that has characterised the past two-three years. The paradox that exists at the core of the whole issue will, however, not disappear. ■